

Intron content, a duplicated uncharacterised ORF,
and mito-nuclear balance: a comparative and
functional anatomy of the *Pleurotus ostreatus*
mitochondrial genome

Richard Barker^{1*}, Ana Sofia Leiva¹, Manisha Dagar¹,
Ayma Rizwan¹, Tayla Koenig¹, Adriana Kaley Sanchez¹,
Simone X. Moulton¹, Marshall Porterfield¹

¹[AUTHORS: affiliation].

*Corresponding author(s). E-mail(s): [AUTHORS: corresponding email];

Abstract

Fungal mitochondrial genomes vary several-fold in size within a single genus, and the usual explanation is intron content. We test that directly across twelve complete *Pleurotus* mitogenomes, annotating all of them with one pipeline rather than relying on their deposited features, which vary enormously in completeness. Size spans 60,694 to 102,950 bp and correlates with detected group I intron content ($r = +0.89$) and more strongly with open reading frame count ($r = +0.96$) — consistent with introns and the homing endonucleases they encode being acquired together. Within *P. ostreatus* alone the range is 65,277 to 73,085 bp, so the same process operates below the species level. The blue oyster mitogenome contains little internal duplication: two repeats totalling 802 bp (1.1% of the genome), but one of them duplicates an uncharacterised open reading frame at 84.5% identity. Of twenty predicted ORFs with no Swiss-Prot homologue, a more sensitive Pfam search assigns function to none, yet four are conserved in at least six of eleven other *Pleurotus* mitogenomes and expressed in at least half of sixteen RNA-seq libraries — candidate genes that current databases cannot name. Screening the nuclear proteome against MitoCarta3.0 and curated Swiss-Prot localisations predicts 631 nuclear-encoded mitochondrial proteins (5.0% of the proteome), and the ratio of mtDNA-encoded to nuclear-encoded mitochondrial expression is highest in the exudophore, though replicate ranges overlap and this remains an observation rather than a result.

Keywords: mitogenome, *Pleurotus ostreatus*, group I intron, gene duplication, MitoCarta, mito-nuclear communication

DRAFT

Companion to the mitogenome annotation paper, which describes the corrected annotation and the intron evidence in full. All values are generated from the analysis repository and verified by `scripts/32_audit_numbers.py`. [AUTHORS] markers indicate items only the authors can supply.

1 Introduction

Fungal mitochondrial genomes are unusually plastic. Within a single genus they routinely vary several-fold in length while encoding essentially the same small set of proteins, and the standard explanation is mobile intron content: group I introns, and the homing endonucleases they carry, invade conserved genes and expand the genome without adding respiratory function [1]. The extreme case is the 135 kbp *Agaricus bisporus* mitogenome, where 43 group I introns occupy 45% of the sequence [2].

That explanation is widely repeated and less often tested within a genus with a consistent annotation. The difficulty is that deposited mitogenome annotations differ enormously in completeness — the companion paper to this one shows that the reference used here carried thirteen features where our pipeline recovers fifty-three — so comparing published feature counts measures annotation effort as much as biology.

We therefore annotated twelve complete *Pleurotus* mitogenomes with a single pipeline and asked: does intron content explain size; is any of the sequence duplicated; can the uncharacterised open reading frames be assigned a function or at least shown to be real; and, since mitochondrial function is jointly encoded by two genomes, is nuclear-encoded mitochondrial expression coordinated with the mitochondrial genome's own output across tissues.

2 Results

2.1 Mitogenome content

The *P. ostreatus* BOM_ss5 mitochondrion is 71,949 bp at 26.6% GC and, under the corrected annotation, carries 20 protein-coding genes, 25 tRNAs, 2 rRNAs and 6 spliced introns (Fig. 1). Coverage is markedly uneven: the ribosomal RNA regions reach 10^6 while much of the protein-coding complement sits between 10^1 and 10^3 .

2.2 Intron content tracks genome size, within and between species

Across twelve mitogenomes, length spans 60,694 bp (*P. citrinopileatus*) to 102,950 bp (*P. giganteus*), a 1.7-fold range with no corresponding change in the respiratory gene set (Table 1).

Detected group I intron content correlates with length at $r = +0.89$, and ORF count more strongly at $r = +0.96$ (Fig. 2). The second correlation is not independent of the first: group I introns encode homing endonucleases, so an intron gain adds both sequence and an ORF. Together they support the standard account.

The effect operates below the species level. Among the seven *P. ostreatus* mitogenomes here, length ranges from 65,277 bp (PC9.15) to 73,085 bp (N009) — a 7.8kb spread within one species, with the smaller genomes carrying three to four detected group I intron hits and the larger seven to eight. Our own strain sits at the larger end.

Detected intron span is a lower bound: covariance models capture the conserved core rather than the whole intron. For BOM_ss5 the models detect 1,123 bp where split-read evidence in the companion paper puts the true spliced total at 4,332 bp, roughly fourfold higher. Detected span is therefore a comparable index across genomes, not an absolute measurement, and it does not by itself account for the whole size difference.

2.3 Little duplication, but what there is duplicates an unknown gene

Self-alignment recovers only two internal repeats of at least 200 bp, together 802 bp or 1.1% of the genome. This mitogenome is not built from repeated sequence.

Both repeats are nonetheless interesting. All-versus-all comparison of the 51 predicted ORFs finds four paralogous families. Three are expected: the NADH dehydrogenase subunits nad2, nad4 and nad5 share ancestry rather than representing duplication, and two families of intron-encoded endonucleases (aI3, aI5, aI8) are homing endonucleases, which proliferate by their nature.

The fourth family is not expected. CM148777.1_26 (64,085–64,510) and CM148777.1_28 (66,884–67,339) have no Swiss-Prot homologue, and they correspond exactly to the larger internal repeat at 84.5% nucleotide identity — a duplicated uncharacterised ORF. Both copies are present in seven of eleven other *Pleurotus* mitogenomes, so the duplication predates the strain, but both are poorly expressed here (five reads and zero reads respectively), which is equally consistent with a pseudogenised pair.

2.4 Sensitive search does not name the uncharacterised ORFs, but conservation and expression identify four candidates

Twenty predicted ORFs have no Swiss-Prot hit. Scanning them against Pfam — a profile method substantially more sensitive than BLAST — assigns an informative domain to **none**. The single hit obtained is to a *Caenorhabditis* neuropeptide-like family at $E = 8.8 \times 10^{-4}$, which we regard as a low-complexity artefact rather than a functional assignment.

Homology search is therefore exhausted, and we fall back on two orthogonal criteria: is the ORF conserved in other mitogenomes, and is it transcribed? Four ORFs satisfy both, being present in at least six of eleven other *Pleurotus* mitogenomes and

139 detected in at least eight of sixteen libraries (Table 2, Fig. 3a). One further ORF is
140 present in a single other genome and is most likely strain-specific or spurious.

141 These four are candidate mitochondrial genes that no current database can name.
142 We make no claim about what they do.

143

144 2.5 A predicted nuclear-encoded mitochondrial proteome

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146 Reciprocal best hits between the 12,521 nuclear proteins and MitoCarta3.0 give
147 399 predicted mitochondrial proteins; a one-way screen would have returned 844,
148 which is why reciprocity was required. Curated Swiss-Prot mitochondrial localisations
149 independently identify 467. The union is **631 proteins, 5.0% of the proteome**.

150 The two approaches are complementary by construction. MitoCarta is a mam-
151 malian inventory, so fungal-specific mitochondrial proteins are invisible to it; Swiss-
152 Prot contains curated yeast and filamentous-fungal entries but covers only 41% of this
153 proteome at all. The union is conservative and should be read as a floor.

154

155 2.6 Mito-nuclear balance differs between tissues, but the 156 ranges overlap

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158 Because mitochondrial function is encoded by two genomes, their relative output is
159 measurable. Expressing both on the same DESeq2 size factors, the ratio of mtDNA-
160 encoded to nuclear-encoded mitochondrial expression is highest in the exudophore
161 (median 1.51) and similar across the other three tissues (0.53–0.74; Table 3, Fig. 3b).

162 Both exudophore replicates exceed every fuzzy mycelium replicate. They do not
163 exceed every library: one exuding mycelium library reaches 1.02 and one nodule library
164 0.94, against 1.14 for the lower exudophore replicate. With $n = 2$ for the exudophore
165 and overlapping ranges, this is an observation to follow up rather than a result.

166 We flag one methodological point behind it. An earlier version of this comparison
167 used raw mitochondrial counts against normalised nuclear counts, and reported the
168 highest ratio in nodule with a correlation of +0.92 across tissues. Both were artefacts
169 of the deepest library sitting in that group. Applying matched size factors moved the
170 maximum to the exudophore and dropped the correlation to +0.43. Ratios between
171 two genomes are only interpretable when both carry the same normalisation.

172

173 3 Discussion

174

175 The comparative result is a clean confirmation of an accepted model, obtained under a
176 consistent annotation: within *Pleurotus*, mitogenome size tracks group I intron content
177 and the ORF load that accompanies it, and the relationship holds within *P. ostreatus*
178 as well as between species. Whether the intron differences between strains reflect recent
179 mobility or long-standing lineage differences is not answerable from sequence alone.

180 The more suggestive observations are negative or preliminary. That Pfam names
181 none of twenty uncharacterised ORFs, while four are both conserved and expressed, is
182 a statement about databases rather than about the organism: mitochondrial ORFs of
183 this kind are numerous in fungal mitogenomes [3] and remain almost entirely unchar-
184 acterised. A duplicated uncharacterised ORF conserved across seven genomes but

essentially untranscribed is the kind of feature that is easy to annotate away and hard to interpret.

The mito-nuclear ratio is worth pursuing precisely because the exudophore is where the other analyses in this series also point — an oxidative, respiratorily active structure. A shifted balance between the two genomes would be consistent with that. Establishing it needs more replicates than these libraries provide.

3.1 Limitations

Annotation is computational throughout; no gene model has been verified experimentally. The comparative set is twelve genomes, adequate for a correlation but not for phylogenetically controlled inference, and the species are related enough that the points are not independent. Detected intron span underestimates true intron content roughly fourfold and does so unevenly. The predicted nuclear mito-proteome inherits MitoCarta’s mammalian bias and Swiss-Prot’s coverage limits. All tissue statements rest on twelve libraries with the exudophore at $n = 2$. Nothing here demonstrates retrograde signalling; the data speak to expression balance only.

4 Methods

Twelve complete *Pleurotus* mitogenomes were retrieved from NCBI and annotated with the pipeline described in the companion paper: tRNAscan-SE [4], barrnap [5], EMBOSS `getorf` under genetic code 4, and DIAMOND [6] identification against Swiss-Prot [7]. Group I and II introns were detected with Infernal [8] `cmsearch` against Rfam [9] models at $E < 0.01$. BOM_ss14, the sibling nucleus of the same dikaryon, was included as a control and returned counts identical to BOM_ss5.

Internal repeats and pairwise synteny used `nucmer` [10] (`--maxmatch --nosimplify` for self-alignment), filtering the trivial diagonal and retaining alignments of at least 200 bp. ORF paralogy used all-versus-all DIAMOND with single-linkage clustering. Pfam [11] domains were assigned with `hmmsearch` [12] at $E < 10^{-3}$.

MitoCarta3.0 [13] human sequences were searched reciprocally against the nuclear proteome, retaining reciprocal best hits. Swiss-Prot subcellular-location annotations were parsed from the flatfile. Mitochondrial and nuclear expression were placed on common DESeq2 [14] size factors before any ratio was computed.

Figures

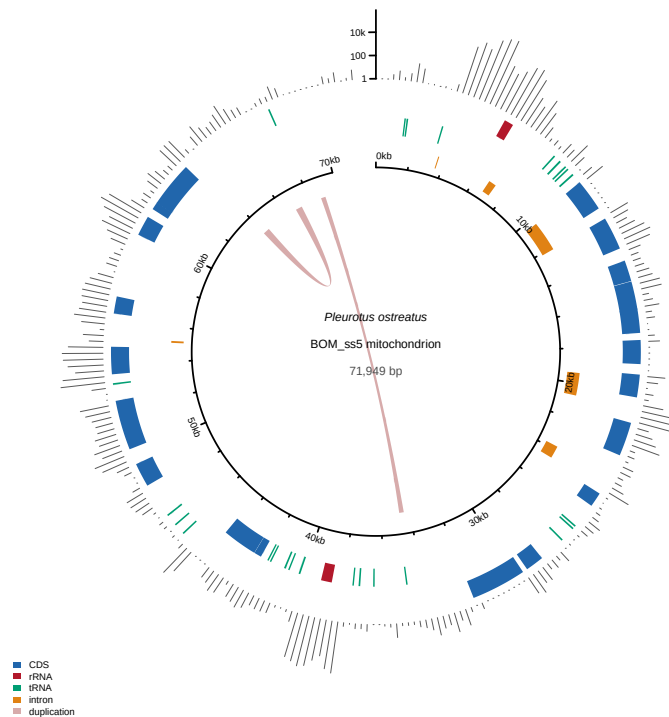


Fig. 1 The blue oyster mitochondrial genome. From the outside: pooled RNA-seq depth (log scale); protein-coding, ribosomal and transfer RNA features on the forward then reverse strand; spliced introns; coordinate axis. Interior links join the two internal repeats; the larger duplicates an uncharacterised ORF at 84.5% identity.

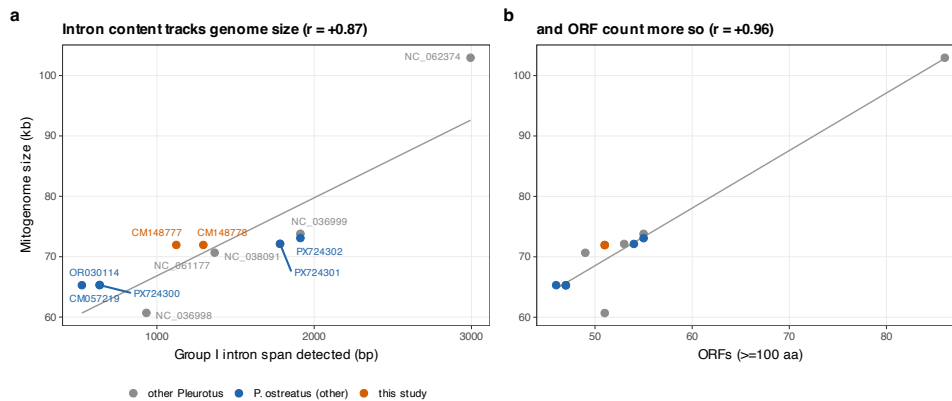


Fig. 2 Intron content tracks mitogenome size across *Pleurotus*. **a**, Genome size against detected group I intron span. **b**, Against ORF count. All twelve genomes annotated with one pipeline.

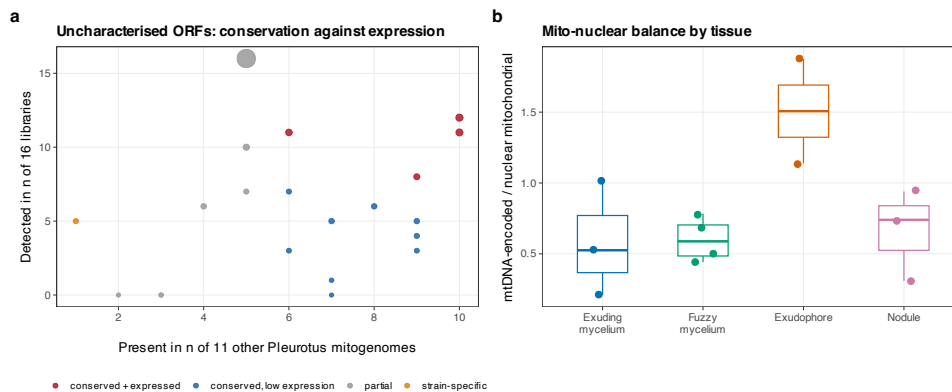


Fig. 3 Uncharacterised ORFs, and mito-nuclear balance. **a**, Each uncharacterised ORF by conservation across other *Pleurotus* mitogenomes and detection across libraries; point size is read support. **b**, Ratio of mtDNA-encoded to predicted nuclear-encoded mitochondrial expression, per library, both on matched size factors.

Tables

Table 1 Complete *Pleurotus* mitogenomes, all annotated with the pipeline used here rather than with their deposited features.

Species / strain	Accession	Length (bp)	GC%	tRNA	ORFs	gpI hits	Intron bp
<i>P. citrinopileatus</i>	NC_036998.1	60,694	29.0	24	51	2	933
<i>P. ostreatus</i> PC9.15	CM057219.1	65,277	26.2	25	47	3	523
<i>P. ostreatus</i> N001	PX724300.1	65,303	26.2	25	47	4	636
<i>P. ostreatus</i>	OR030114.1	65,311	26.2	25	46	4	636
<i>P. pulmonarius</i>	NC_061177.1	70,671	25.3	25	49	6	1,367
<i>P. ostreatus</i> BOM_ss14	CM148778.1	71,947	26.6	25	51	5	1,295
<i>P. ostreatus</i> BOM_ss5 (this study)	CM148777.1	71,949	26.6	25	51	4	1,123
<i>P. ostreatus</i> F515	PX724301.1	72,132	26.7	25	54	7	1,783
<i>P. cornucopiae</i>	NC_038091.1	72,134	26.7	25	53	7	1,783
<i>P. ostreatus</i> N009	PX724302.1	73,085	26.7	25	55	8	1,912
<i>P. platypus</i>	NC_036999.1	73,807	26.8	25	55	8	1,912
<i>P. giganteus</i>	NC_062374.1	102,950	25.0	25	86	12	2,994

gpI hits are Rfam group I covariance-model matches; the span they cover is a lower bound, since the models capture the conserved core rather than the full intron.

Table 2 Uncharacterised mitochondrial ORFs: conservation across *Pleurotus* against expression.

ORF	Other genomes	Libraries	Reads	In rRNA block
CM148777.1_27	10/11	12/16	584	no
CM148777.1_14	10/11	11/16	524	no
CM148777.1_44	9/11	8/16	218	no
CM148777.1_30	9/11	5/16	100	no
CM148777.1_21	9/11	4/16	60	yes
CM148777.1_37	9/11	3/16	29	yes
CM148777.1_43	8/11	6/16	106	no
CM148777.1_20	7/11	5/16	104	yes
CM148777.1_28	7/11	1/16	5	no
CM148777.1_26	7/11	0/16	0	no
CM148777.1_33	6/11	11/16	376	no
CM148777.1_51	6/11	7/16	58	yes
CM148777.1_11	6/11	3/16	30	no
CM148777.1_50	5/11	16/16	14,070	yes

No Swiss-Prot hit and no informative Pfam domain. An ORF conserved in most genomes and expressed in most libraries is a candidate gene; one present in a single strain is more likely spurious.

Data availability. https://github.com/dr-richard-barker/Myco_tissue_RNAseq. Corrected annotations for all twelve mitogenomes, the comparative inventory, the ORF conservation table and the predicted nuclear mito-proteome are included.

Author contributions. [AUTHORS: CRediT statement for all eight authors.]

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Table 3 Ratio of mtDNA-encoded to predicted nuclear-encoded mitochondrial expression, per library.

Tissue	<i>n</i>	Min	Median	Max
Exudophore	2	1.139	1.507	1.875
Nodule	3	0.309	0.740	0.940
Fuzzy mycelium	4	0.442	0.588	0.784
Exuding mycelium	3	0.209	0.525	1.016

Both terms carry the same DESeq2 size factors. Ranges overlap between tissues and the exudophore has *n* = 2; this is descriptive.

Competing interests. [AUTHORS: declaration.]

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